

Tutorial: Creating a Picture Book in Sigil with Separate Text and Illustrations

Introduction

Sigil is a free, open-source EPUB editor that allows you to create and edit eBooks with precision. When creating a picture book, it's important to keep text and images separate for better formatting control, accessibility, and reflow on different devices.

Step 1: Prepare Your Materials

- **Text content:** Write your story text in a plain text editor or word processor.
 - **Illustrations:** Prepare your images in web-friendly formats (JPEG, PNG, SVG). Optimize them for size and resolution (usually 72-150 dpi for eBooks).
 - **Folder structure:** Organize your files in folders (e.g., /images for illustrations, /text for chapters).
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Step 2: Open Sigil and Create a New EPUB

1. Launch Sigil.
 2. Click **File > New** to create a new EPUB project.
 3. Save your project with a meaningful name.
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Step 3: Add Your Text Content

1. In Sigil, right-click the **Text** folder in the Book Browser panel.
2. Select **Add > New HTML File**.
3. Name your file (e.g., chapter1.xhtml).
4. Double-click the file to open the editor.
5. Paste or type your story text here.

Important: Keep only the text here. Do not embed images directly in this file.

Step 4: Add Your Illustrations

1. Right-click the **Images** folder in the Book Browser.
2. Select **Add > Existing Files**.
3. Browse and select your illustration files.

4. The images will be added to the EPUB package but not embedded in the text files yet.
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Step 5: Link Illustrations Separately from Text

To keep text and images separate but still display them together on a page, use HTML and CSS positioning.

Example HTML structure in your text file (chapter1.xhtml):

```
<div class="page">
  <div class="text">
    <p>Leo and Drago began their journey.</p>
  </div>
  <div class="image">
    
  </div>
</div>
```

Step 6: Add CSS for Layout

1. Right-click the **Styles** folder.
2. Select **Add > New CSS File** and name it (e.g., styles.css).
3. Open the CSS file and add styles to position text and images side by side or as desired.

Example CSS:

```
.page {
  display: flex;
  align-items: center;
  justify-content: space-between;
  margin: 20px;
}

.text {
  width: 50%;
  font-size: 1.2em;
  line-height: 1.5;
}

.image {
  width: 45%;
  text-align: center;
}

.image img {
  max-width: 100%;
  height: auto;
  border-radius: 10px;
}
```

4. Link this CSS file in your HTML files by adding inside the <head> section:

```
<link rel="stylesheet" type="text/css" href="../../Styles/styles.css" />
```

Step 7: Preview Your Book

1. Use Sigil's **Book View** or **Preview** mode to see how the text and images appear together.
 2. Adjust CSS styles as needed to improve layout and spacing.
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Step 8: Repeat for Each Page

- Create a new XHTML file for each page or chapter.
 - Add text and link images separately as shown.
 - Use consistent CSS for uniform style.
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Step 9: Finalize and Export

1. Validate your EPUB using Sigil's built-in validation tool (**Tools > Validate EPUB**).
 2. Fix any errors.
 3. Save your EPUB file.
 4. Test on different eReaders or apps to ensure text and images display correctly.
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Tips for Mixing Text and Illustrations

- **Keep text in HTML elements** (<p>, <div>) separate from images ().
- Use CSS `flexbox` or `grid` to control layout without embedding images inside text blocks.
- Use `alt` attributes on images for accessibility.
- Avoid embedding text inside images to keep content searchable and scalable.
- Use margins and padding in CSS to create whitespace between text and images.
- Consider responsive design so your book looks good on various screen sizes.